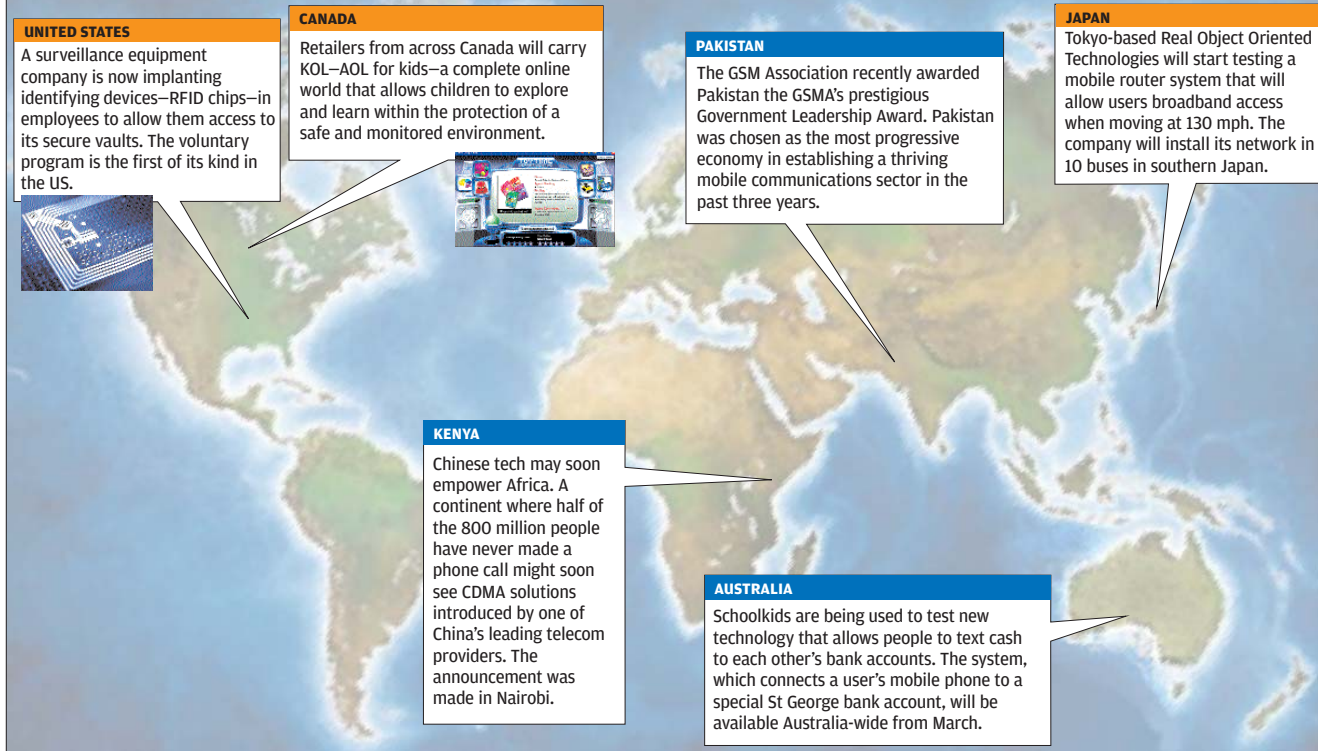


 The Digital World

A Round-up Of Technology News From Across The Globe



bank," AOL says. "We think that will help cut down on spam, but we don't want consumers to pay any extra."

The technology for this will be provided by Goodmail, whose paid-for certified system has been tested by the US Red Cross. Goodmail promises to prevent senders of bulk spam from using the service.

So analyse this—will the scheme be helpful? Spammers won't pay, so their mails will be routed through the spam filters and be caught; legit mails, sent by, say, your bank, will come through promptly. It sounds a reasonable idea, but when you think about it, it's not, really. Industry experts said the plan is "dead on arrival" because it will have little impact on spam. What's more, it's likely to prompt a huge consumer backlash, since users wouldn't be able to control what kind of e-mails they receive.

"It guarantees delivery of paid-for bulk e-mail based on the sender paying, not based on users' preferences," said Andrew

Lochart, senior director of marketing for Postini, a managed e-mail service provider. "In other words, it will allow more, not less, unwanted e-mail through to users." Lochart added, "AOL and Yahoo plans don't actually prevent spam, and they ask legitimate senders to pay for the sins of the real spammers."

The idea of allowing only legitimate businesses to pay to send e-mail also raises questions about who will play the role of deciding what's legitimate and what's not, said other industry experts. Who will decide if incoming mail is truly high-value? It may be high value for AOL or Yahoo!, but is it high-value for the user?

AN IMPENDING SPLIT

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